



Preparing to strike

Crewmen on the aircraft carrier *USS Constellation*, positioned off the coast of North Vietnam during Linebacker I, fit bombs to an F-4 Phantom jet on May 23, 1972.

Losses minimized

In Linebacker I, the US Air Force flew 18,000 sorties and lost 44 aircraft (five to flak, 12 to SAMs, and 27 to North Vietnamese interceptors). The US Navy flew more than 23,600 sorties and lost 45 planes (27 to flak, 17 to SAMs, and one to fighters). While the Air Force provided very elaborate electronic countermeasures and flak suppression for its missions, special training in aerial maneuver tactics enabled Navy crews to achieve a 13 to 1 kill-to-loss ratio against Hanoi's planes. Flying at a low altitude also reduced Navy losses to SAMs.

Losses of both Navy and Air Force aircraft were minimized by warnings of North Vietnamese fighter activity provided by US warship radars and Air Force intelligence units.

The worst day for the Americans was on June 27, when four Air Force Phantoms were shot down, three by MiGs, with no North Vietnamese losses.

Assessing the impact

In all, North Vietnam lost 62 of its own fighter interceptors to the Americans. The United States had demonstrated to North Vietnam that Washington would respond forcefully to its actions in the South and would exact a cost for supplying the insurgents. However, as US National Security Council staffer Philip Odeen argued at the time, US intelligence depended heavily on photography, which provided scant data about the state of North